

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 706

By Gardenhire

A RESOLUTION to honor Junior Lee Hankins, the longest-serving county commissioner in Bledsoe County history.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly take great pleasure in recognizing a gentleman who has distinguished himself as a vital and vibrant public servant for more than four decades; and

WHEREAS, Junior Lee Hankins's forty-four-year legislative tenure ranks him as the longest-serving county commissioner in Bledsoe County history and one of the longest-serving county commissioners in the State of Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Hankins has always supported projects that not only benefit his district and community but also Bledsoe County as a whole, and he has worked to keep taxes low for the community's farmers and families by expanding the tax base through growth; and

WHEREAS, he has earned the respect of his colleagues on both sides of the aisle through his spirit of cooperation and his willingness to listen to other viewpoints; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Hankins was named 2022 Bledsoe County Republican of the Year in appreciation of his many contributions to the prosperity of his community; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Hankins has ever been a diligent worker, from an early age and into his retirement years; he is a lifelong farmer, having maintained beef and dairy herds for most of his career; and

WHEREAS, he has also worked as a coal miner, logger, sawmill operator, service station operator, school bus driver, and a heavy equipment operator of singular ability and versatility; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Hankins is also a problem solver who can repair almost any device, and he has earned his fellow citizens' admiration as "the best hillbilly engineer in the state"; and

WHEREAS, a lifelong resident of Bledsoe County, Junior Lee Hankins is the son of Johnnie and Laura Swafford Hankins and a loving and supportive family man who treasures his wife of sixty-eight years, Shirley Johnson Hankins; their children, Gary Hankins, Stanley Hankins, Colleen Hankins Spears, and Dale Hankins; and his many grandchildren, great-grandchildren, and great-great-grandchildren, who adore him as "the best Pa" ever; and

WHEREAS, he has been an outstanding role model for his family members, teaching them the importance of a good work ethic, patience, and service to others; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Hankins's friends and neighbors regard him as a wise and knowledgeable man, but he is humble and unassuming in his daily conduct, always willing to give help or advice when asked; and

WHEREAS, together, he and Mrs. Hankins have built a home at which every child, neighbor, and friend feels welcome, and they often set aside their responsibilities to talk and have coffee with their visitors; and

WHEREAS, Junior Lee Hankins became a Christian at the age of sixteen and now serves as a deacon at his place of worship, Winesap Free Will Baptist Church, where he is legendary for his listening ear, serving heart, unending patience, and hard work and determination; and

WHEREAS, a member of First Families of Bledsoe County and First Families of Tennessee, Mr. Hankins is an avid fisherman who once caught a 100-pound halibut in Alaska; and

WHEREAS, Junior Lee Hankins is a man of rare ability and dedication, and his life of purpose and commitment should be appropriately commemorated; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor Junior Lee Hankins, the longest-serving

county commissioner in Bledsoe County history, paying tribute to his forty-four-year tenure with that body and extending our best wishes for much continued success and happiness.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.